

Spotify Campfire-

Project overview

Have you ever been on a camping trip? Maybe you have or maybe you haven't, but regardless, most people are aware of the unique environment it creates. A campfire brings people together, encouraging them to share stories and take turns singing their favourite songs with a group of friends. There is a certain kind of magic in these moments, and the foundation of my Social Music Discovery System is built on that same feeling.

The method of music recommendation in this system is based on shared spaces called rooms that users can join. Within these rooms, users are grouped together with others who have similar music tastes and mixes. Each participant takes turns playing a song for the group, closely mirroring the experience of sharing songs around a campfire. As the session continues, the songs played are stored in a campfire song history, allowing users to revisit and reflect on the music that was shared.

To enhance the social aspect of discovery, the system also includes features such as a live chat system and profile viewing. These features allow users to discuss the songs being played in real time and explore each other's profiles to better understand the people behind the music. This transforms music discovery from a passive activity into an interactive and communal experience.

In contrast to Spotify, which is often a single user-based application that places little emphasis on direct social connection, this system helps users feel a stronger sense of community. Music is meant to connect people, and through the Spotify Campfire system, users can find their group of music listeners more naturally and meaningfully as they take turns playing music that they love.

User research

The base I decided to build upon is the Spotify music streaming service. Spotify is widely recognized for its strong design and refined design language, which made it an ideal foundation for introducing a native feature that emphasizes the mood and magic of listening to music as a group. This feature is intended to feel like a natural extension of the platform and must be easily accessible and intuitive for users to adopt.

To ensure an optimal user experience, I initially created a flowchart to map out the user flow. This helped me plan my first steps, optimize decision points, and establish a clear and structured path for the creation of the feature. By visualizing the flow early on, I was able to identify potential friction points and refine the experience before moving into detailed design.

The target audience for this product consists of young adults and teenagers who want to meet new people with similar music tastes but feel unable to do so in real life. Many of these users often turn to unmoderated or unreliable platforms such as Reddit to find music communities. To better understand and design for this audience, I created a user persona to keep the needs, motivations, and frustrations of the intended users in mind throughout the entire design process.

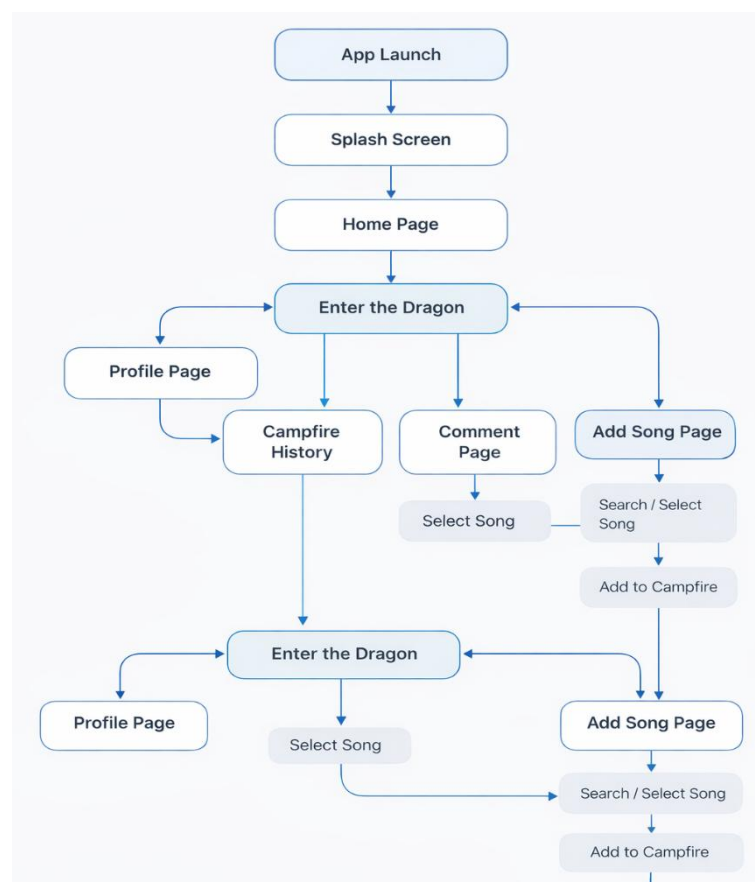


Fig 1.1 – user flow diagram

The following diagram illustrates the user flow that I designed to ensure the feature is easy for users to access and use without breaking their existing listening flow. The structure of the flow is intentionally very direct and very simple, allowing users to understand how to access the feature at a glance and interact with it intuitively.

The term Enter the Dragon was used as an early working title for the feature. At the time, the final name and full concept had not yet been established, and this placeholder reflected the early stage of the ideation process during which the user flow was created.

For the user persona, I decided to use a student from IIT Roorkee as my case study. I chose this group because it represents a large and diverse population with varied music preferences and social backgrounds. Many students in this demographic simply want to listen to their music while also having the opportunity to meet a few people who share similar tastes.

By grounding the persona in a real and relatable context, I was able to design the feature with a clearer understanding of the user's needs, motivations, and social environment, ensuring that the experience feels relevant and meaningful to the intended audience.



Fig 1.2- user persona indicating IIT Roorkee students

Ideation

For the ideation phase, I prefer using pen and paper. It is the most creative medium for me and allows me to quickly get my thoughts out without any constraints. This approach enables rapid exploration of ideas before committing to more structured or digital formats.

It was important that the feature felt organic and easy to use, which meant the design needed to remain simple while still complementing Spotify's existing user interface. At the same time, the feature had to support several core components, including a chat system, a vote skip system that allows a majority of participants to skip a song, and a campfire song history system. Balancing simplicity with functionality was a key focus during this stage of ideation.

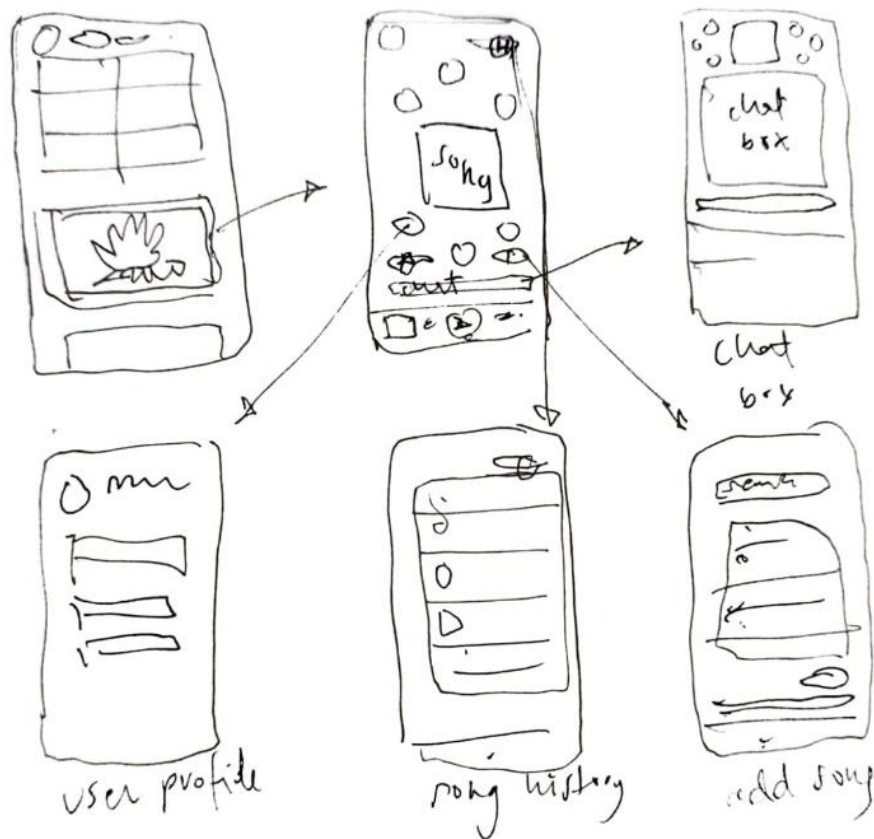


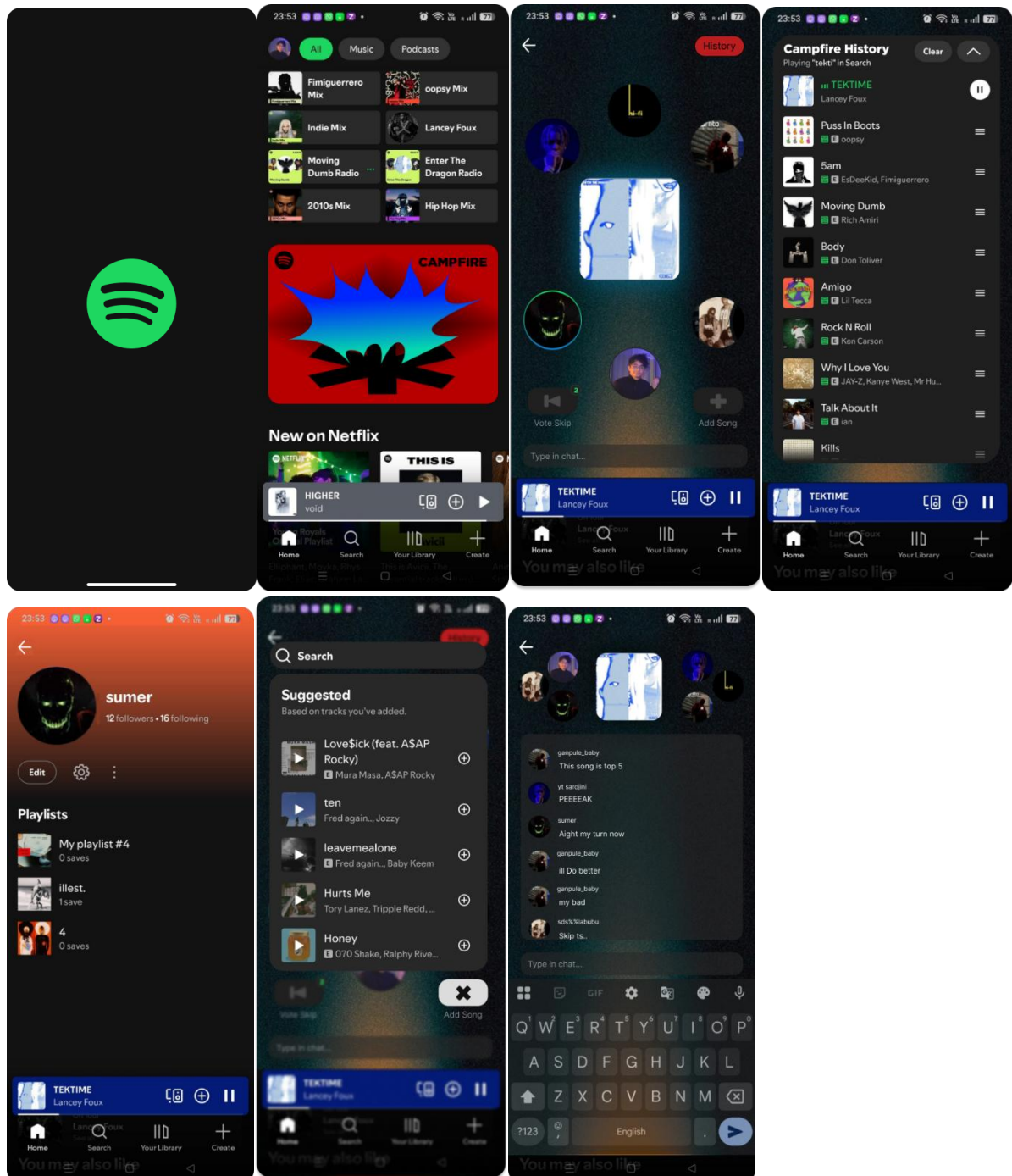
Fig 2.1 – Rough hand drawn ideation sketches and wireframes

This process allowed me to develop a rough understanding of the user flow and begin creating the prototype in Figma. Using Figma was essential, as the prototype needed to adhere closely to Spotify's established design language and function as a one-to-one scaled model of the intended working system.

To achieve this level of accuracy, I conducted extensive research into Spotify's design language, including its user interactions, iconography, typography, and overall visual behaviour. This ensured that the feature felt native to the platform and consistent with the existing user experience.

Visual Design

PRODUCT DESIGN OVERVIEW



The design language focuses on capturing the warmth of a campfire environment while remaining consistent with Spotify's established visual identity. Gradients are used to

recreate Spotify's signature background effect, while the colour palette was carefully selected to reinforce the outdoor campfire theme.

A dark green tone was chosen to evoke the feeling of being in a lush outdoor forest, while also tying directly into Spotify's primary brand colour. A light orange gradient emerging from the bottom of the screen is used to represent fire. Rather than being harsh or aggressive, this gradient is subtle and warm, creating a cozy and inviting atmosphere.

The UI buttons and components were designed as close recreations of the original Spotify interface elements, with new features carefully styled to align with Spotify's design language. The use of dark grey for buttons combined with bright green highlights helps maintain visual consistency and gives the feature a native feel, as if it were always part of the Spotify application.

Campfire feature button design

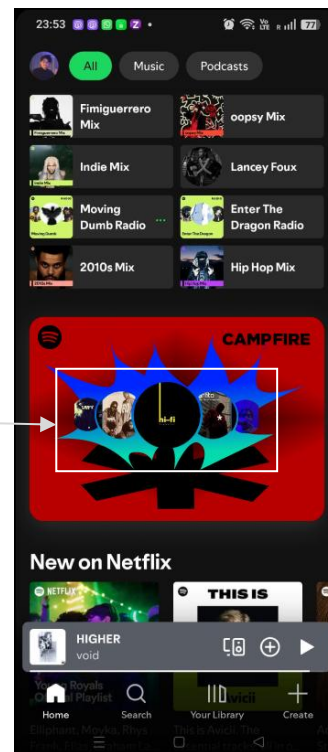
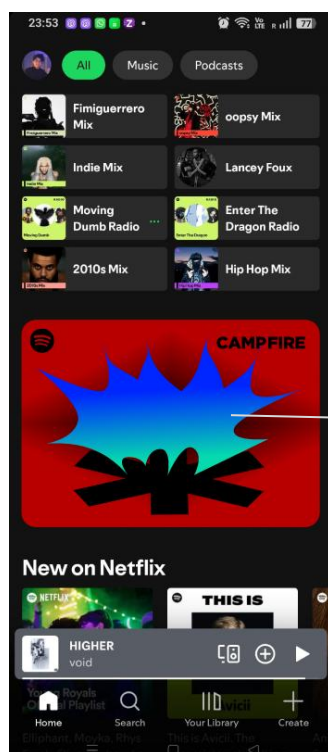


Fig 3.1 – Campfire feature button

Fig 3.2 – Campfire feature hover state button

The icon was designed to immediately grab the user's attention and feel visually loud. The unconventional fire form was intentionally used to create visual interest and differentiate the feature from standard UI elements. The use of red and blue aligns with colors commonly found in Spotify's user interface, alongside the inclusion of the signature Spotify logo and the feature name positioned on the top left and right of the button respectively.

The unconventional fireplace design communicates energy and movement, helping to lure users into engaging with the feature. In addition, the Hover State reveals the participants already present in the room. This preview builds curiosity and provides a social cue, further encouraging users to click on and explore the Campfire feature.

Campfire song history button design

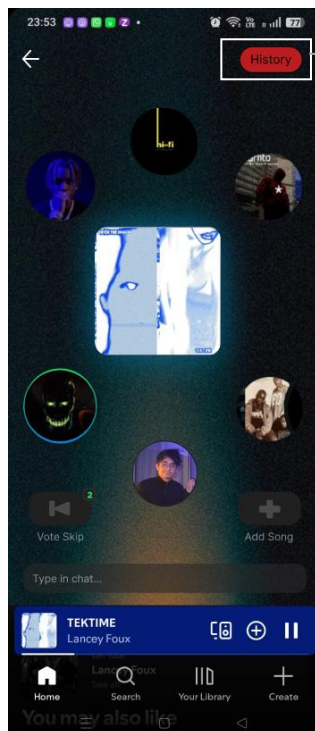


Fig 3.3 – song history feature button

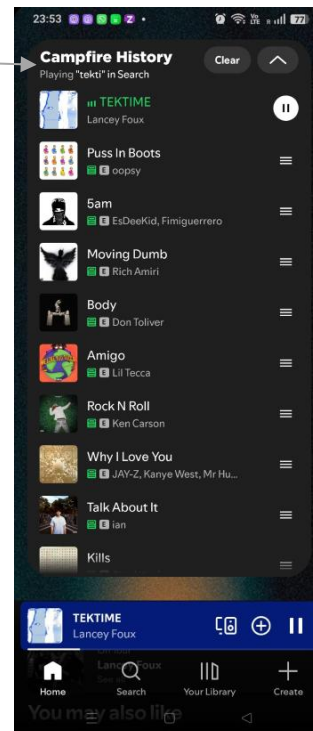


Fig 3.4 – song history opened state

Once a user enters the feature, or enters the Campfire, they are greeted by five other participants, with six users being the maximum allowed per room. Upon joining, a song is already playing, and the interface presents several buttons that were designed to be as intuitive and self-explanatory as possible.

The first button is the history button, as shown above. This feature allows users to scroll through the songs that were previously played around the campfire. By providing access to past songs, users can revisit tracks, discover new music, and explore genres beyond what is currently playing in the room. This makes the music discovery process more accessible and engaging, rather than limiting discovery to only the songs being played in real time.

Profile viewing feature design

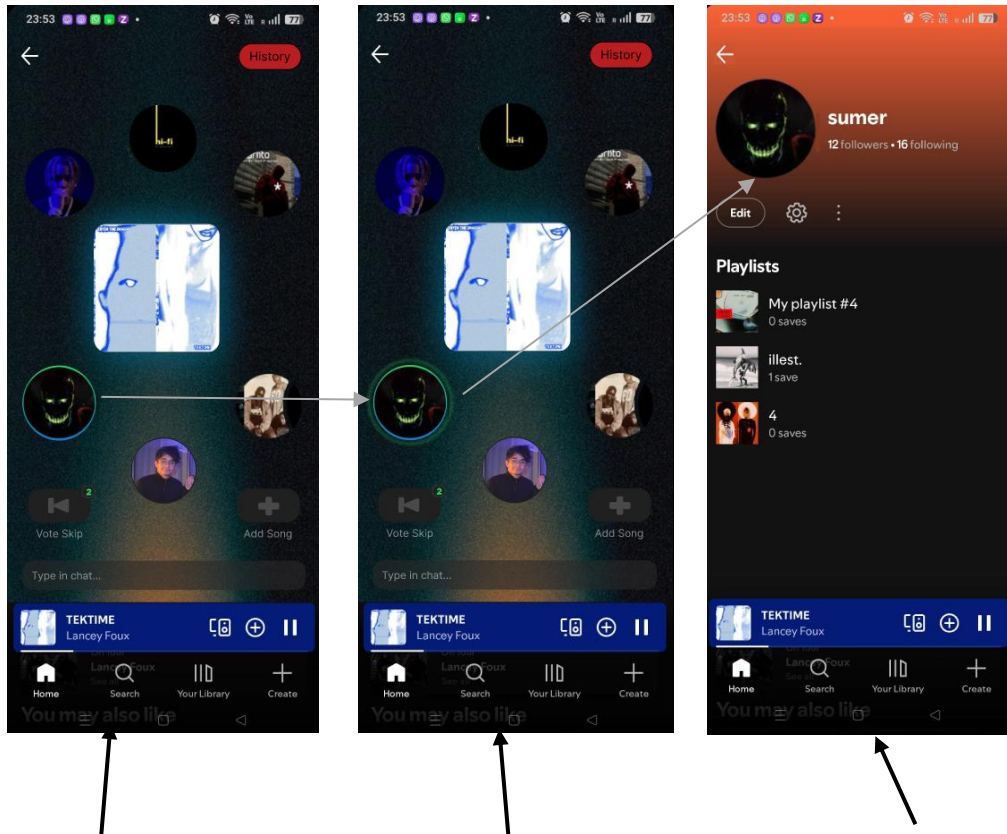


Fig 3.5 – base state

Fig 3.6 – profile hover state state

Fig 3.7 – opened profile

There is a visual indicator surrounding the profile of the user whose turn it currently is. This helps make the turn based system more manageable, as each participant can easily keep track of the order and estimate when their own turn might occur.

When hovering over a profile, a light green glow appears around it, acting as a visual cue and subtly prompting users to interact with their campmates' profiles. Users are able to click on any profile to explore what their fellow campmates listen to and the playlists they have created. This feature encourages discovery beyond just songs and enables users to form connections with people outside their pre existing social circles.

Chat box design

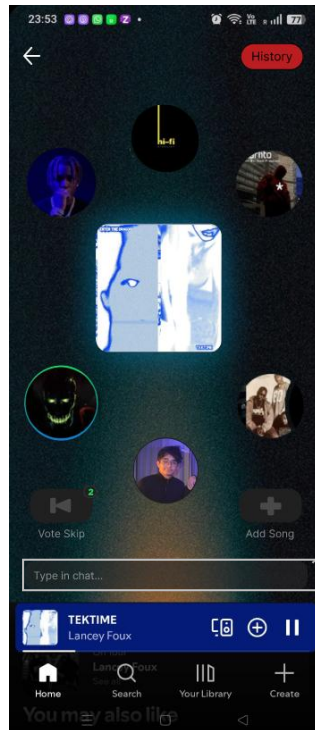


Fig 3.8 – chat bar button

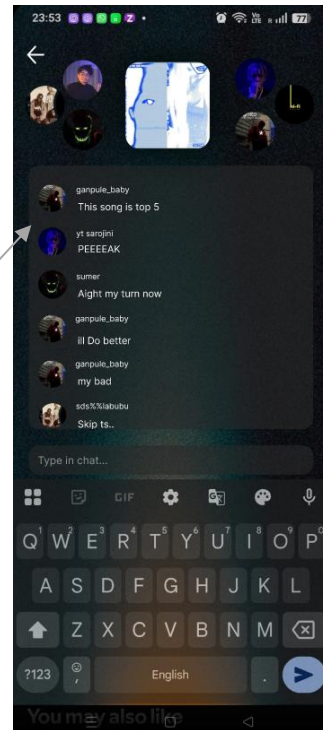


Fig 3.9 – chat box opened state

The main feature of the Campfire that elevates its level of interactivity beyond anything Spotify has previously offered is the chat system. Through this feature, campmates are able to interact with one another in real time by commenting on songs, sharing recommendations, cracking jokes, and engaging in a wide range of social interactions.

The chat interface uses a minimalistic design to keep users focused on the conversations themselves rather than on unnecessary visual distractions. To maintain a strong connection between the chat and the Campfire room, icons and song information are minimized and positioned at the top of the screen. This ensures that the album artwork and participant profiles remain visible, preventing any visual or experiential disconnect between the chat and the shared listening environment.

Add Song button design

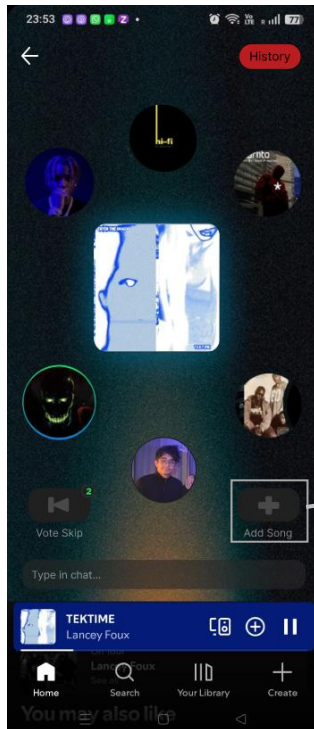


Fig 3.10 – add song feature button

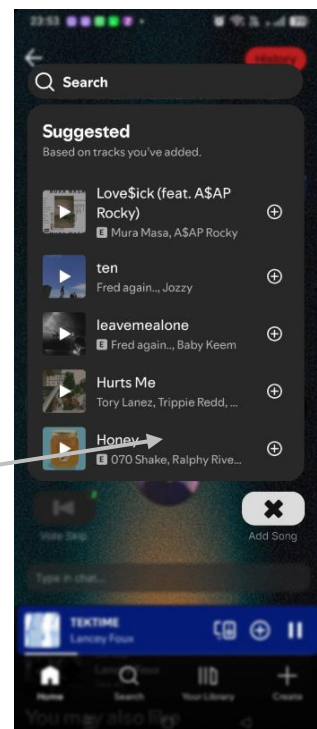


Fig 3.11 – add song opened state

The add song feature is the most important component of the Campfire experience. Without it, the room would simply consist of strangers with no shared musical interaction. The add song button is designed in grey to match Spotify's existing design language, with familiar iconography and clear text that make its purpose immediately understandable to users.

This button allows users to queue a song that will be played when it is their turn. Once selected, a menu containing recommended songs and a search bar appears. The background of the Campfire room is blurred to reduce visual distraction and help users focus on finding and deciding which song to add.

A subtle interaction detail was introduced in the form of the plus icon smoothly transitioning into a cross. This small animation adds a sense of polish and clarity, improving the overall quality of the user experience while clearly indicating a change in state.

Vote skip button design

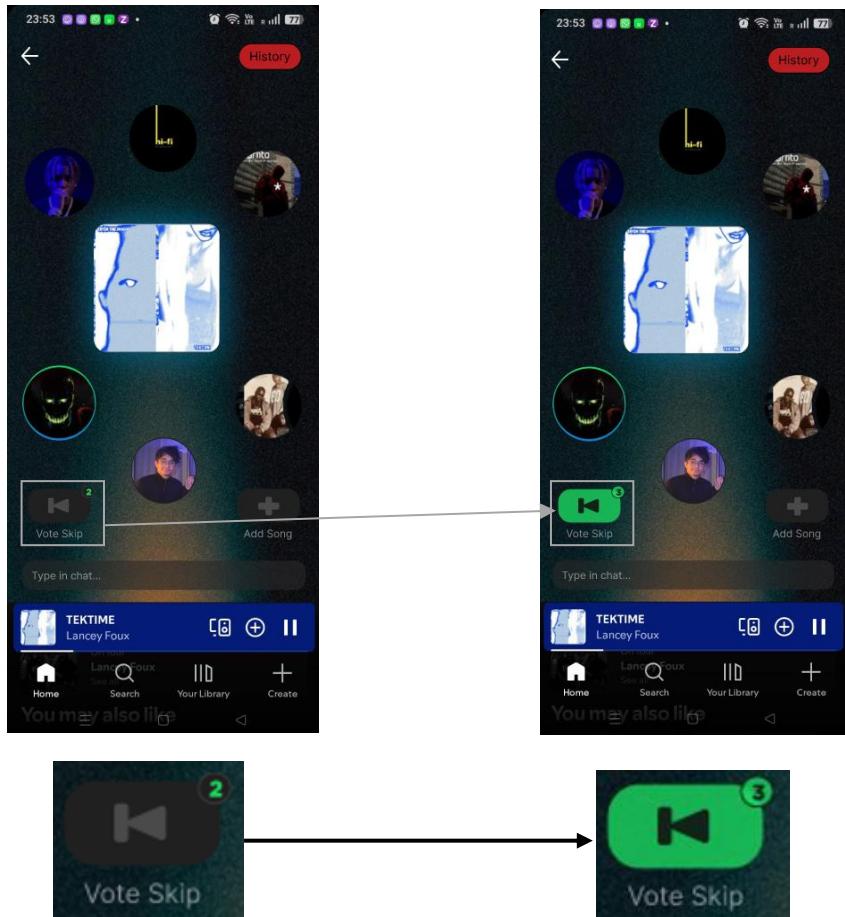


Fig 3.12 – vote skip button

Fig 3.13 – vote skip pressed state(count +1)

Finally, the vote skip button was introduced to add an element of playfulness and collective decision making to the Campfire experience. It provides a light-hearted way for the group to respond to songs that may not align with everyone's taste. Each campmate can anonymously vote to skip a song, and if the tally reaches four participants, representing a majority, the song is skipped.

This system allows songs that do not suit the group's overall preferences to be moved past quickly, reducing moments of disengagement or boredom. The anticipation that others may also vote to skip a song helps maintain momentum within the session. The chat system further supports this interaction, as users can openly discuss their reactions and encourage others to vote skip when a song is not resonating.

Together, these features promote more organic social interaction and subtly influence users to be more thoughtful when selecting songs, reinforcing the feeling that music selection is a shared group experience rather than an individual action.

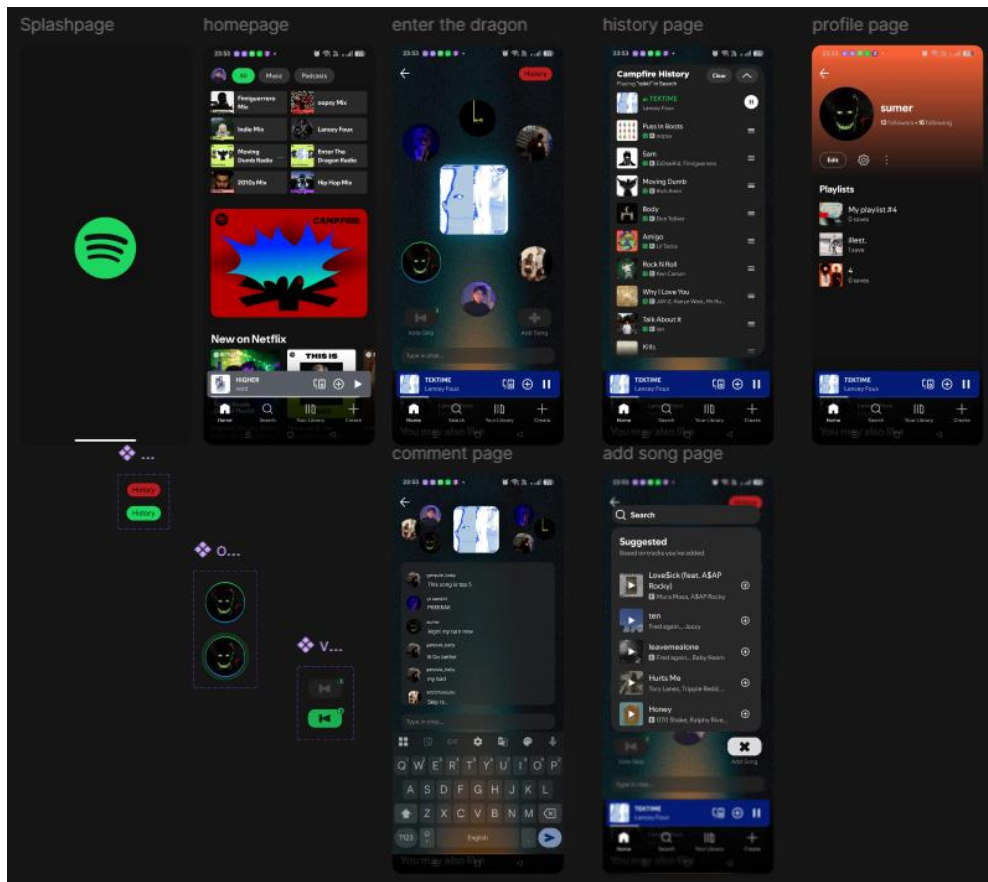


Fig 3.14 – Visual design frames overview

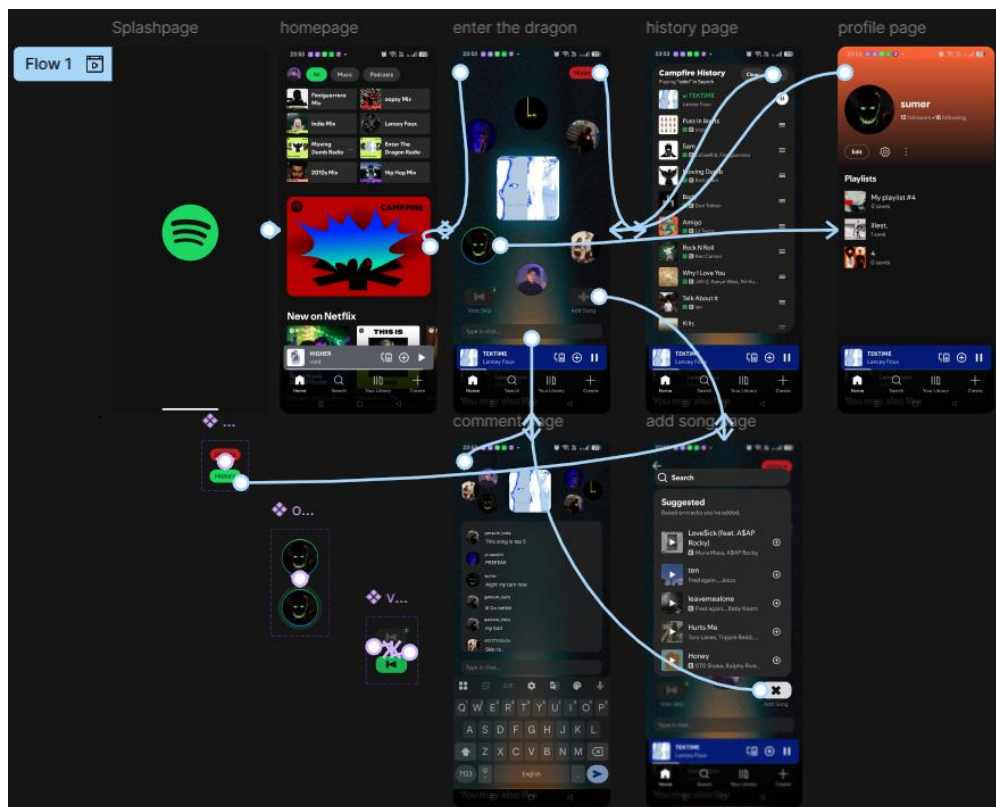


Fig 3.15 – Frame prototyping overview

Final product (Figma Link)-

<https://www.figma.com/design/Dzmiv9lmYZSggvVp5MaAfl/college-work?node-id=77-84&t=0wX09osR1hx3R8wC-1>

Link 1.1 – Figma project edit/access link (open on computer)

<https://www.figma.com/proto/Dzmiv9lmYZSggvVp5MaAfl/college-work?node-id=77-84&t=0wX09osR1hx3R8wC-1>

Link 1.1 – Figma prototype link (open on computer)